Week 1 Notes: Introduction to Popular Music

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Reconstructed from the Week 1.1 and 1.2 slides. No lecture recording — examples and discussion from class are not captured here.

The Four Key Themes

Week 1.1 sets out the frame for the entire course. Everything in Weeks 2–4 is an instance of one or more of these:

1. **Art versus commerce**
2. **Industry**
3. **Technology**
4. **Identity**

Plus a fifth that the slides add at the end: **…and History.**

These are not four separate topics so much as four angles on one question — what happens to music when it becomes a product that an industry makes, sells, and sorts into categories for particular audiences. Keep them in mind as a checklist: when the course introduces a genre, a performer, or a technology, ask which of the four is doing the work.

Frith: "The Industrialization of Music"

This is the theoretical backbone of the course, and the slides quote it three times with page numbers:

> "The contrast between music-as-expression and music-as-commodity defines twentieth-century pop experience" (231)

> There is a distinction between music and songs, and then, the music industry, "which determines what songs, singers and performances are and can be" (232)

> "By 1945 the basic structure of the modern music industry was in place. Pop music meant pop records, commodities, a technological and commercial process under the control of a small number of large companies" (236)

The argument in one line: the industry does not merely distribute music that already exists — it **determines what songs, singers and performances can be**. That verb is the whole claim.

Frith organises the consequences under three headings:

- **The effects of technological change**
- **The economics of pop**
- **A new musical culture**

Why the 1945 date matters. It is the hinge for everything that follows in this course. Weeks 2–4 trace the structure Frith says was "in place" by then: sheet-music publishing (Tin Pan Alley), the record industry and its sorted categories (race records, hillbilly), and the small number of large companies that controlled the process.

The slides pair this with contemporary examples — the *Billboard* Hot 100, the *KPop Demon Hunters* soundtrack taking around 40% of all K-pop streaming, BTS vinyl sales figures, and a Billboard Canada story on a University of Alberta study finding 87% of Canadian musicians view generative AI negatively. The point is that Frith's argument is not a historical curiosity: the same tension between expression and commodity is live now.

Music and Subjectivity

Subjectivity, per Brabazon: "the condition of being a subject: i.e., the quality of possessing perspectives, experiences, feelings, beliefs, desires, and/or power."

> "The tether between listening choices and constructing a sense of self establishes boundaries of belonging, community, inclusion and exclusion" (Brabazon, "Listening to Music")

That sentence is the one to remember: what you listen to does not just reflect who you are, it **draws a line** around who is inside and outside a group. The rock/pop and genre-purist arguments later in the course are versions of exactly this.

Three questions the slides pose:

- Why does music become popular at a certain time?
- Why do we like listening in certain situations (times and places)?
- Are there certain types of music we like to listen to in certain times or places?

The portable-listening thread. The slides illustrate this with a hardware sequence — **Sony Walkman → Sony Discman (1988) → iPod range → streaming** — ending on a Spotify-style contextual interface ("It's Monday Afternoon: play music for — Brand New Music / Working (No Lyrics) / Boosting Your Energy / Working in an Office / Working to a Beat").

The arc is the point: technology progressively **detaches listening from a place** (the living room) and reattaches it to an *activity* and a *mood*. By the streaming era the platform itself proposes the context. That connects back to Frith — the industry shaping not just what music is, but when and how it is used. It also sets up Week 4's transistor radio: the same story, three decades earlier.

Defining Popular Music

The definition is not fixed. Popular music changes in its definitions as it moves through time and space — historical and cultural context matters. This is why the course keeps returning to how categories were named and renamed.

What "popular" carries. The word often suggests inferiority — "material of the masses" — and sits inside a **"high" versus "low" culture** opposition. But the slides are explicit that **these boundaries are very fluid**. Treat high/low as a claim someone is making, not a fact about the music.

> "Popular music becomes part of the shared experiences of a group or community, offering pleasure, resistance and narratives of love, romance, sex, masculinity, femininity and desire" (Brabazon)

The working definition — three parts. Popular music:

- **Has currency beyond a local audience**
- **Gains new audiences, meanings and contexts**
- **Shapes our identity**

That middle point is doing more work than it looks like: a song's meaning is not fixed at the moment of release. "New San Antonio Rose" becoming a Bing Crosby pop hit, Ray Charles's "I Got a Woman" becoming a Kanye West sample, Little Richard's songs

becoming Beatles covers — each is a case of the same music gaining new audiences, meanings and contexts.

Musical Analysis: The Vocabulary

The main sonic elements of music, per the slides:

Element	What it is
Rhythm (beat)	The pulse and its pattern — where the emphasis falls
Melody	The tune; the line you sing back
Harmony	The chords supporting the melody
Voice	Timbre and delivery, not just pitch
Riffs	Short repeated instrumental figures
Hooks	The part designed to catch and stay
Lyrics	The words and what they narrate

This list is the toolkit for the listening assignments. The instructor's later warning (Week 2.1, quoting Brabazon) is that it is easy to **default to lyrics alone** — so push toward rhythm, voice, and riffs when writing about a track.

How This Week Carries Forward

Week 1 is abstract on its own. It becomes useful once you can see each theme operating in a later week:

Week 1 concept	Where it reappears
Frith: the industry determines what songs and singers *can be*	Billboard renaming country (hillbilly → American Folk → Country and Western); race records; the Nashville Sound smoothing Patsy Cline's yodel

Week 1 concept	Where it reappears
Art versus commerce	Patsy Cline pushed toward pop; genre purists calling crossover a compromise; rock coded "authentic" against pop
Technology	Electrified instruments (1938); pickups and amplification; transistor and car radios; Sun Records' studio sound
Identity and subjectivity	Youth culture as "a celebration of difference and pleasure"; the postwar generation gap; fan communities
"Popular" as high vs low	The press calling rock 'n' roll a "communicable disease"; "the white man's blues"
Gains new audiences, meanings and contexts	Crossover: "New San Antonio Rose," "Hound Dog," "That's All Right," "Maybellene" from "Ida Red"

If an exam question asks *why* something happened rather than *what* happened, the answer usually lives in this week.

Self-Check

- [ ] Name the four key themes and give one example of each from a later week
- [ ] State Frith's central claim in one sentence, and explain what "determines" is doing in it
- [ ] Say what was "in place" by 1945 and why that date anchors the course
- [ ] Define subjectivity, and explain Brabazon's claim about listening and boundaries of belonging
- [ ] Give the three-part definition of popular music
- [ ] Explain why "popular" is a loaded term, and why high/low is called fluid
- [ ] List the seven sonic elements and name one song where each is the most striking feature

Reconstructed from slides only — if the review sheet names examples from this week that are not here, they came from the lecture.

Readings

Simon Frith, "The Industrialization of Music" (*The Popular Music Studies Reader*, eds. Bennett, Shank and Toynbee, Routledge 2000, pp. 231–238) — this week's core reading. The slides quote it at pp. 231, 232 and 236.

Tara Brabazon, *Popular Music: Topics, Trends & Trajectories* (Sage, 2012) — the source of the subjectivity definition, the "Listening to Music" quote on belonging, and the definition of popular music as shared experience.

What Later Lectures Reveal About Week 1 (inferred)

There is no recording for this week. But the Week 3 and 4 lectures refer back to it, and those callbacks are the best evidence of what was said in class. Where a callback covers something not on the slides, it was spoken — and the instructor thought it worth repeating.

What the later lecture says	Where	What it tells you about Week 1
"We talked a little bit about this in our first lecture" — authenticity, and rock coded as masculine ("very loud bands featuring men") against "the feminized sphere of pop"	Week 4.2	The **gendered rock/pop binary and authenticity** were introduced in the first lecture. They are **not on the Week 1 slides**, so this was spoken emphasis. High exam value.
"This definition of genre that we introduced" — genre not only as musical features but as an industry imagining its audiences	Week 3.3	A definition of **genre as industry construction** was set up early (Week 1 or 2). The instructor treats it as a shared term.
High art and classical music vs popular stars — "you don't really need to know how to read music. You can just listen"	Week 4.2	The **high/low distinction** from this week is still being used four weeks later, now to explain Elvis.

The four themes are Frith restructured. Lining up Week 1.1 against Week 1.2 shows the course's framework is built directly on the reading:

Week 1.1 theme	Frith (Week 1.2)
Art versus commerce	"music-as-expression and music-as-commodity" (231)

Week 1.1 theme	Frith (Week 1.2)
Industry	"the economics of pop"; "a small number of large companies" (236)
Technology	"the effects of technological change"
Identity	"a new musical culture" — plus Brabazon on subjectivity and belonging

If you can explain this table, you can explain the course.

Inferred emphasis for the midterm:

1. Authenticity and the gendered rock/pop binary — spoken in Week 1, repeated in Week 4
2. Frith's claim that the industry *determines* what songs and singers can be
3. Genre as an industry category, not just a sound
4. "Popular" as a loaded term; high/low as fluid